

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 133

REWORK v2 — correction for review, original remains locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Eating well when family gives you conflicting food advice

"Family advice may be well meant, but it can also feel pressuring — you can choose what suits you and set boundaries around your own meals without having to justify every choice."

Why it matters now

As your family settles into a longer routine with your child, food advice from grandparents, in-laws, aunts, uncles and neighbours doesn't necessarily taper off — sometimes it's about your child's plate, but often it's still about yours: what you should eat more of, less of, or avoid altogether. Much of this advice is offered with real affection, even when it's outdated, contradicts current guidance, or doesn't match what works for you — but that doesn't mean it never feels like pressure, especially when it's repeated often or tied to your child's wellbeing.

This week isn't about which specific claims are right or wrong — it's about how you relate to that advice: you're allowed to listen without automatically complying, to decline without a lengthy justification, and to change your mind when something genuinely makes sense, on your own terms and timeline.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

If you're managing a condition family members aren't fully aware of: your own care team's guidance takes priority over general advice from relatives, however well-intentioned — you're not obliged to explain your medical situation to justify a food choice.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are

meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Rajasthani/Marwari home cooking (bajra roti, gatte ki sabzi, ker sangri, laal maas, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

Family food advice after having a baby is common almost everywhere. It can come from a genuine wish to help, even when it doesn't match current guidance or your own preferences — though it can also feel like pressure, especially when it's frequent or insistent. Either way, you don't have to accept advice to be polite about it, and you don't owe anyone a detailed justification to decline it.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Moong dal cheela with onion and tomato (2 pieces) with mint chutney and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with bajra roti (2 pieces) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Gatte ki sabzi, gram-flour dumplings in a spiced yogurt curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup dumplings) with bajra roti (2 pieces) and a ker sangri sabzi
- B. Laal maas, Rajasthani red mutton curry (100g mutton) with bajra roti (2 pieces) and a ker sangri sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted moong dal namkeen (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Wheat roti (2 pieces) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with wheat roti (2 pieces) and a lauki sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — When the advice conflicts with your own care team's guidance

Most everyday food advice is harmless either way, and can be taken or left as you prefer. But when it touches something your own clinician has specifically advised — a supplement dose, a food to avoid, your meal or medication timing — that individual guidance takes priority, even over advice that's well-intentioned or widely believed.

Worth knowing: If a family member's food advice conflicts with something your doctor, dietitian or lactation consultant has specifically told you, follow your own care team — they know your individual situation, test results and history in a way a well-meaning relative usually doesn't. It's fine to say so plainly: "My doctor's asked me to do it this way for now."

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Moong dal cheela with grated carrot (2 pieces) with mint chutney and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion paratha (2 eggs, 2 paratha) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Ker sangri sabzi with wheat khichdi (1 cup khichdi, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal) with bajra roti (2 pieces)
- B. Chicken curry, Marwari-style (100g chicken) with bajra roti (2 pieces) and a ker sangri sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Wheat roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a bhindi sabzi
- B. Egg curry, Marwari-style (2 eggs) with wheat roti (2 pieces) and a cauliflower sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — When advice comes with pressure to eat more, or less

"Eat more, you need it for the baby" and "don't eat that, it's too heavy" can both show up in the same week, sometimes from the same person. How much you eat is still your own call, guided by your own appetite and any care plan you follow — you can thank someone for their concern and still serve yourself the portion that's right for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Poha, flattened rice with peanuts, onion and curry leaves (1 1/2 cups) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Gatte ki sabzi (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup dumplings) with bajra roti (2 pieces) and a gawar phali sabzi
- B. Safed maas, Rajasthani white mutton curry (100g mutton) with bajra roti (2 pieces) and a gawar phali sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal-and-vegetable khichdi with carrots and peas (1 1/2 cups, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Chicken curry, Marwari-style (100g chicken) with wheat roti (2 pieces) and a lauki sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Traditional postpartum-diet beliefs

Many families carry specific beliefs about foods that help or harm milk supply, healing or the baby's temperament — some line up with current evidence, some don't, and most are simply neutral either way. You can enjoy a food because it's meaningful to your family without needing it to have a proven physiological effect, and skipping one is a reasonable choice too, without needing to predict exactly what difference it will or won't make.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Moong dal cheela with capsicum (2 pieces) with mint chutney and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji with spinach (2 eggs) with bajra roti (2 pieces) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Ker sangri sabzi with chana dal (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal) with bajra roti (2 pieces)
- B. Laal maas, Rajasthani red mutton curry (100g mutton) with bajra roti (2 pieces) and a bhindi sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted chana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Wheat roti (2 pieces) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-peas curry (100g paneer) with wheat roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — Setting a boundary without turning it into a conflict

You don't need a debate to decline advice or a dish that doesn't suit you — a short, warm line usually does the job: "That sounds good, I'll keep it in mind," or "I'm doing it this way for now, but thank you." Repeating the same calm response, without justifying it further each time, is often what actually ends the conversation.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Moong dal cheela with grated bottle gourd (2 pieces) with mint chutney and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato omelette (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Gatte ki sabzi (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup dumplings) with bajra roti (2 pieces) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Fish curry, Rajasthani-style (100g fish) with bajra roti (2 pieces) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted makhana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Wheat roti (2 pieces) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Egg curry, Marwari-style (2 eggs) with wheat roti (2 pieces) and a bhindi sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — When it's actually worth changing your mind

Not all advice is worth dismissing either — sometimes a relative's suggestion is genuinely useful, or points to something worth asking your own care team about. Weighing advice on what it actually says, rather than on who said it or how strongly, works both ways: it's fine to take it seriously, and just as fine to set it aside.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Dalia, cracked wheat porridge with mixed vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion bhurji (2 eggs) with bajra roti (2 pieces) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Ker sangri sabzi with moong dal (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal) with bajra roti (2 pieces)
- B. Chicken curry, Marwari-style (100g chicken) with bajra roti (2 pieces) and a gawar phali sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Chana dal-and-vegetable khichdi with cauliflower and beans (1 1/2 cups, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Paneer-and-capsicum curry (100g paneer) with wheat roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Moong dal cheela with onion and tomato (2 pieces) with mint chutney and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with bajra roti (2 pieces) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Gatte ki sabzi, gram-flour dumplings in a spiced yogurt curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup dumplings) with bajra roti (2 pieces) and a ker sangri sabzi
- B. Laal maas, Rajasthani red mutton curry (100g mutton) with bajra roti (2 pieces) and a ker sangri sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted moong dal namkeen (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Wheat roti (2 pieces) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with wheat roti (2 pieces) and a lauki sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Was there a piece of advice from someone this week that you decided was actually worth keeping — or one you were glad to set aside?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

The next set of weeks continues this series' steady, one-topic-at-a-time approach to your own nutrition and wellbeing.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.
- If a family member's food advice conflicts with something your own clinician has specifically told you, follow your clinician's individual guidance — it's based on your own history and situation in a way general advice isn't.

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Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

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REWORK v2 — correction for review, original remains locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Niacin (vitamin B3), and where it fits into your everyday meals

"Niacin helps your body convert food into usable energy, and comes from a wide range of everyday foods — chicken, fish, mushrooms, peanuts, whole grains and legumes — plus a real, if partial, contribution your body makes by converting dietary tryptophan; deficiency is rare with a varied diet, though high-dose supplements are a different matter, can affect blood glucose as well as the liver, and belong under a clinician's supervision."

Why it matters now

Niacin (vitamin B3) is one of the B vitamins your body relies on to convert food into usable energy. It's found across a wide range of everyday foods — chicken, fish, mushrooms, peanuts, whole grains and legumes — and your body also converts some dietary tryptophan (from protein-rich foods generally) into niacin, a real, if partial, contribution to your overall intake, not merely an irrelevant backup. For most people eating a varied diet, this need is met without any deliberate tracking.

High-dose niacin supplements, sometimes prescribed for cholesterol management, are a different situation entirely — they can cause flushing and, at higher doses, affect liver function and raise blood glucose (particularly relevant if you manage diabetes), and belong under a clinician's supervision. That's separate from anything in this week's food-based guidance, which needs no special caution for most people.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

If you take a prescribed niacin supplement for cholesterol management, or you manage diabetes: follow your clinician's dosing and monitoring plan — high-dose niacin can affect blood glucose as well as the liver, so this is a different situation from niacin in food, and isn't something to adjust based on general guidance like this week's.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Kashmiri Pandit home cooking (nadru/lotus-stem yakhni, haak, dum aloo, rogan josh, tomato chaman, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

Niacin is one of the B vitamins your body uses to convert the food you eat into usable energy. It's found in a wide range of everyday foods, and most people eating a varied diet meet their needs without any special planning or tracking.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Nadru, lotus-stem yakhni-style curry (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rajma, kidney bean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked rajma) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a haak saag
- B. Rogan josh, Kashmiri mutton curry (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a haak saag

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Tomato chaman, paneer in a tomato-based curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a mixed vegetable sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Everyday food sources, and the body's own conversion

Chicken, fish, mushrooms, peanuts and whole grains are all reliable niacin sources. Your body also converts some of the dietary tryptophan you get from protein-rich foods generally into niacin — a real, if partial, contribution to your total intake, not just an irrelevant backup to the foods that contain niacin directly.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Nadru yakhni with mushrooms (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato omelette (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Dum aloo with chana dal (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a haak saag
- B. Kashmiri trout curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a haak saag

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup) and a mushroom sabzi
- B. Kokur, Kashmiri chicken yakhni-style curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — If you take a niacin supplement for cholesterol

If you or someone in your household takes a prescribed niacin supplement, that's a medical decision your clinician is already managing — this week's food-based guidance is a separate, much gentler picture, and doesn't call for the same caution.

Worth knowing: High-dose niacin supplements, sometimes prescribed for cholesterol management, are a genuinely different situation from niacin in food — they can cause flushing, itching and, at high doses, affect liver function and raise blood glucose, which is particularly relevant if you manage diabetes. They need to be started and monitored by a clinician. This isn't a concern with niacin from ordinary meals.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Vegetable dalia, cracked wheat porridge with mixed vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion paratha (2 eggs, 2 paratha) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rajma (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked rajma) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a dum aloo
- B. Rogan josh (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a mushroom sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted chana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Chana dal-and-vegetable khichdi with carrots and peas (1 1/2 cups, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Tomato chaman (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a haak saag

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Deficiency is uncommon with a varied diet

Niacin deficiency (historically known as pellagra) is uncommon where diets include a mix of protein sources, whole grains and legumes — it was historically linked to diets built almost entirely around untreated corn, which is low in usable niacin. If your meals already include some variety across the week, this isn't something you need to actively track.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Nadru yakhni with carrots (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-spinach bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Haak saag with moong dal (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal) with rice (1 cup cooked)
- B. Kokur yakhni-style curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Egg curry, Kashmiri-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a mushroom sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — Good options if you eat mostly vegetarian

Mushrooms, peanuts, whole grains, legumes and dairy all contribute niacin without needing meat, fish or eggs — a plant-forward day can meet this need comfortably as long as it includes some variety across these groups.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Nadru yakhni with mushrooms and peas (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Dum aloo with rajma (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked rajma) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a haak saag
- B. Kashmiri trout curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with an urad dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Tomato chaman with peas (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — The pattern across your week matters, not one meal

One meal without an obvious niacin source, or one particularly protein-rich day, doesn't meaningfully change your status either way — as with most of the nutrients covered in this series, it's the overall pattern across the week that matters, not any single plate.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Semolina upma with mixed vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rajma with dum aloo (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked rajma) with rice (1 cup cooked)
- B. Rogan josh (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans-and-carrot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal-and-vegetable khichdi with mushrooms and peas (1 1/2 cups, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Kokur yakhni-style curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Nadru, lotus-stem yakhni-style curry (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rajma, kidney bean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked rajma) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a haak saag

B. Rogan josh, Kashmiri mutton curry (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a haak saag

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup)

B. Tomato chaman, paneer in a tomato-based curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a mixed vegetable sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Looking back across this run of weeks, which single change has made the most noticeable difference to how you feel day to day?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

The next set of weeks continues this series' steady, one-topic-at-a-time approach to your own nutrition and wellbeing.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.
- High-dose niacin supplements need clinician supervision — they can cause flushing and, at high doses, affect liver function and raise blood glucose (particularly relevant if you manage diabetes). Don't self-prescribe a high-dose niacin supplement; this caution doesn't apply to niacin from ordinary meals.

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 135

REWORK v2 — correction for review, original remains locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Eating well as you return to work outside the home

"A tighter morning, a workday away from your own kitchen and an evening still full of childcare all make eating well harder logistically, not less important — a little planning around what travels well, what's quick, and what you can eat at your desk goes further than trying to eat perfectly."

Why it matters now

Returning to paid work outside the home, whether for the first time since your baby arrived or after a longer stretch, reshuffles when and how you eat far more than what you're actually capable of eating well. Mornings get tighter, lunch depends on what's available where you work, and evenings often start a second round of childcare and household tasks right when you're already tired.

None of this makes eating well impossible — it just calls for a bit more planning around what travels, what reheats, and what you can eat quickly without much preparation. This week's meals lean toward options that hold up outside a home kitchen.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

If your medication needs specific timing around meals: build that timing into your new work schedule deliberately rather than letting it slip on busy days — a phone reminder can help until the new routine settles in.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are

meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Andhra/coastal Telugu home cooking (pappu, gongura pachadi, pulusu, pesarattu, gutti vankaya, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

Returning to work outside the home changes the logistics of eating far more than the underlying need — you still need regular, adequate meals, just fit around a schedule that isn't entirely your own anymore. This week is about practical adjustments, not a stricter standard.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Pesarattu, moong dal dosa (2 medium) with ginger chutney and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Pappu, Andhra dal (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a gutti vankaya
- B. Andhra chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a gutti vankaya

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Quick mornings that still cover the basics

A rushed morning doesn't have to mean skipping breakfast — a dosa or paratha made the night before and reheated, boiled eggs prepped in advance, or even a glass of milk with fruit on the way out are all reasonable options when there isn't time for a full sit-down meal.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Pesarattu with onion (2 medium) with ginger chutney and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Gongura pappu, sorrel-leaf dal (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal) with rice (1 cup cooked)
- B. Andhra mutton curry (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked), a small portion of gongura pachadi (2 tbsp) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a bhindi sabzi
- B. Egg curry, Andhra-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — Eating enough through a meeting-heavy day

It's easy for lunch to slide later and later on a busy day, or to be skipped altogether. Keeping something portable on hand for exactly those days is a practical safeguard, not a sign you're not managing well.

Worth knowing: If work meetings routinely push your meals very late, a packed snack — nuts, fruit, a boiled egg — that doesn't depend on a break room or canteen timing can help prevent long stretches without food, which often show up later as low energy or overeating in the evening. Keep a boiled egg and any other perishable snack refrigerated, or in an insulated bag with frozen cold packs, and refrigerate it on arrival where possible — discard it if it's been left without temperature control for more than two hours, or one hour above 32°C.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Idli (4 pieces) with sambar and coconut chutney and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion paratha (2 eggs, 2 paratha) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Pappu with gutti vankaya (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked)
- B. Fish pulusu, Andhra tamarind fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a gutti vankaya

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted chana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal-and-vegetable khichdi with carrots and peas (1 1/2 cups, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Andhra chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Staying hydrated and snacking well at a desk

A desk job can make it easy to forget water for hours at a stretch — keeping a bottle within sight is a simple reminder. A handful of nuts or fruit kept at your desk covers you between meals better than the vending machine or the office biscuit tin, though neither is off-limits either. Curd is a good option too, but only if it can stay refrigerated or in an insulated bag with a frozen cold pack — an insulated bag alone, without a cold pack, isn't enough, and refrigerating it again after it's been out too long doesn't make it safe again.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Pesarattu with grated bottle gourd (2 medium) with ginger chutney and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Gongura pappu, sorrel-leaf dal (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal) with rice (1 cup cooked)
- B. Andhra chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked), a small portion of gongura pachadi (2 tbsp) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-peas curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — Office food culture — canteens, treats and potlucks

Cake for a colleague's birthday, a canteen tray that isn't quite what you'd cook at home, or a team lunch you didn't plan for are all a normal part of office life. None of it needs to derail the rest of your day — enjoy what you choose to, and pick up your usual pattern at the next meal.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Pesarattu with methi (2 medium) with ginger chutney and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable omelette (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Pappu (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a gutti vankaya
- B. Prawn curry, Andhra-style (100g prawns) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a gutti vankaya

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted makhana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Egg curry, Andhra-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — The evening second shift — keeping dinner simple

Coming home after a full workday to childcare, cooking and everything else waiting doesn't leave much energy for an elaborate dinner. A simple, repeatable dinner — dal, rice, a vegetable, curd — is a completely adequate choice on these days, not a compromise.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Semolina upma with mixed vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Gongura pappu, sorrel-leaf dal (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked)
- B. Fish pulusu (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked), a small portion of gongura pachadi (2 tbsp) and a spinach sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Chana dal-and-vegetable khichdi with cauliflower and beans (1 1/2 cups, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Andhra mutton curry (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Pesarattu, moong dal dosa (2 medium) with ginger chutney and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Pappu, Andhra dal (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a gutti vankaya

B. Andhra chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a gutti vankaya

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup)

B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

What's one part of your new work routine that's still settling — and one small change that might make eating through it easier?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

The next set of weeks continues this series' steady, one-topic-at-a-time approach to your own nutrition and wellbeing.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.
- If you're carrying food to work, keep curd, cooked eggs and other perishable foods refrigerated, or in an insulated bag with frozen cold packs, and refrigerate on arrival where possible. An insulated bag alone, without a cold pack, isn't enough. Discard perishables left without temperature control for more than two hours — or one hour above 32°C — since refrigerating them again afterward does not make them safe.

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 136

REWORK v2 — correction for review, original remains locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Pantothenic acid (vitamin B5), one of the more overlooked B vitamins

"Pantothenic acid helps your body release energy from food, and its name literally means "from everywhere" in Greek — it's present in nearly every food group, which makes a genuine dietary deficiency rare; you don't need to track it, and a dedicated supplement isn't something most people need."

Why it matters now

Pantothenic acid (vitamin B5) is part of a coenzyme your body uses constantly to release energy from the food you eat. Its name comes from the Greek for "from everywhere," reflecting how widely it's distributed — grains, legumes, vegetables, dairy, eggs, meat, mushrooms and more all contribute small amounts. A genuine dietary deficiency is rare outside severe malnutrition.

You may see pantothenic acid, or the related compound dexpanthenol, marketed in skin and hair products. Most of the supporting evidence relates to topical use, not to eating more of it than a typical varied diet already supplies — this week's meals need no special adjustment either way.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

If you take a prenatal, postnatal or general multivitamin: check what it already contains before adding a separate B-vitamin supplement — combined products can add up unnoticed, and most people don't need an additional pantothenic acid supplement on top of one.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are

meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Gujarati/Kathiyawadi home cooking (thepla, undhiyu, kadhi, khaman, handvo, dal dhokli, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

Pantothenic acid (vitamin B5) is another of the B vitamins your body uses to release energy from food, working as part of a coenzyme your cells use constantly. Its name comes from the Greek for "from everywhere," because it's present in small amounts across nearly every food group — grains, legumes, vegetables, dairy, eggs and meat all contribute.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Methi thepla (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g) and a pickle
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Gujarati kadhi with khichdi (1 cup khichdi, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal and a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice) with an undhiyu
- B. Kathiyawadi chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and an undhiyu

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Thepla (2 pieces) with a moong dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with thepla (2 pieces) and a bhindi sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Everyday food sources, without needing to seek them out

Mushrooms, avocado, sunflower seeds, eggs, whole grains and legumes are all particularly good sources, but because pantothenic acid is so widely distributed, most people meet their needs through ordinary meals without deliberately including any of these.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Handvo, a savoury baked lentil-and-vegetable cake (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato omelette (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Dal dhokli, wheat dumplings in a sweet-and-tangy dal (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with an undhiyu
- B. Kathiyawadi mutton curry (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and an undhiyu

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Thepla (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a mushroom sabzi
- B. Egg curry, Kathiyawadi-style (2 eggs) with thepla (2 pieces) and a cauliflower sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — Deficiency is rare

Because pantothenic acid is so widely present in food, a genuine dietary deficiency is rare on an ordinary varied diet, even one that isn't perfectly balanced — this isn't a nutrient that calls for special attention, and testing should be based on individual indications rather than routine.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Khaman dhokla (2 pieces) with green chutney and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion paratha (2 eggs, 2 paratha) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Undhiyu with rice (1 cup cooked rice, plus a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked tuvar lilva in the undhiyu) and a bhindi sabzi
- B. Kathiyawadi chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted chana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Chana dal-and-vegetable khichdi with carrots and peas (1 1/2 cups, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Paneer-and-peas curry (100g paneer) with thepla (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Skin and hair supplement claims, kept in perspective

You may see pantothenic acid, or a related compound called dexpanthenol, marketed in skin and hair products or supplements. Most of that evidence relates to topical use, not to eating more pantothenic acid than a typical diet already provides — extra dietary intake beyond what you already get from food isn't shown to add a skin or hair benefit on its own.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Methi thepla with grated carrot (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-spinach bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Gujarati kadhi with rice (1 cup rice) and a dal dhokli (includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal)
- B. Kathiyawadi mutton curry (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Thepla (2 pieces) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a beans sabzi
- B. Egg curry, Kathiyawadi-style (2 eggs) with thepla (2 pieces) and a mushroom sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — If you already take a prenatal or postnatal multivitamin

Most prenatal and postnatal multivitamins already include pantothenic acid alongside other B vitamins — you don't need a separate supplement on top of one you're already taking, and combined products can add up unnoticed if you're not tracking what's in each one.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Handvo with grated bottle gourd (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Undhiyu with khichdi (1 cup khichdi, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal and a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice)
- B. Veraval-style pomfret curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and an undhiyu

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Thepla (2 pieces) with an urad dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-capsicum curry (100g paneer) with thepla (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — The pattern across your week matters, not one meal

As with most of the nutrients this series covers, one meal without an obvious source doesn't change anything meaningfully — pantothenic acid's presence across nearly every food group means the overall pattern of eating regular, varied meals through the week already takes care of this one.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Khaman dhokla with grated cabbage (2 pieces) with green chutney and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Dal dhokli (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with an undhiyu
- B. Kathiyawadi chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans-and-carrot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal-and-vegetable khichdi with mushrooms and peas (1 1/2 cups, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg curry, Kathiyawadi-style (2 eggs) with thepla (2 pieces) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Methi thepla (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g) and a pickle
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Gujarati kadhi with khichdi (1 cup khichdi, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal and a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice) with an undhiyu
- B. Kathiyawadi chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and an undhiyu

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Thepla (2 pieces) with a moong dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with thepla (2 pieces) and a bhindi sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Looking back across this run of weeks, which single change has made the most noticeable difference to how you feel day to day?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

The next set of weeks continues this series' steady, one-topic-at-a-time approach to your own nutrition and wellbeing.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 137

REWORK v2 — correction for review, original remains locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Eating well while you're pumping or expressing milk at work

"Pumping at work adds its own logistics — extra fluid, a snack within reach during a hands-limited session, breaks that need to double as actual meals — but not a fundamentally different eating pattern from the rest of this series; a little planning around the routine matters more than any specific 'supply food.'"

Why it matters now

If you are still breastfeeding or expressing milk, this week's guidance may help. If not, the meals below remain usable on their own, and you can simply skip the pumping-related notes — nothing here assumes every mother at this stage has the same additional requirements.

If you're pumping or expressing milk during your workday, the underlying nutrition picture is the same one this series has covered throughout — regular meals, adequate fluid, a dependable protein and calcium source through the day, adjusted to your own appetite, activity and however much you're currently expressing. What's different is the logistics: shorter windows, hands that are often occupied, and breaks that need to cover both a pumping session and something to eat.

There's no special "pumping diet," and no single food that reliably changes your supply. A little planning — water at your pumping station, a snack prepped in advance and kept cold, pairing a session with a meal where your schedule allows — tends to help more than chasing a particular ingredient.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

If you're concerned your supply has genuinely dropped: a lactation consultant or your own clinician can help identify the actual cause — it's rarely a single food, and troubleshooting it yourself based on diet alone often isn't the most useful approach.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Mangalorean/Tulu Nadu home cooking (neer dosa, kori gassi, alsande sukka, pundi, ghee roast, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

Pumping or expressing at work fits into the same general eating pattern this series has covered all along — regular meals, enough fluid, some protein and calcium through the day. What changes is the logistics: less time, less flexibility about when you eat, and sessions that need planning around.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Neer dosa (3 pieces) with coconut chutney and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Alsande sukka, cowpea stir-fry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked cowpeas) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Kori gassi, Mangalorean chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a carrot sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Extra fluid, kept simple

Breastfeeding and pumping both increase your fluid needs somewhat, and a workday can make it easy to lose track of how much you've actually had. Keeping a filled water bottle at your pumping station, alongside your milk and equipment, is a simple habit that removes the need to remember separately.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Neer dosa with grated coconut (3 pieces) with coconut chutney and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Pundi, rice dumplings (3 pieces) with an alsande sukka (includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked cowpeas) and a beans sabzi
- B. Mangalorean mutton curry (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a bhindi sabzi
- B. Egg curry, Mangalorean-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — "Supply foods" and why most of this is a myth

It's easy to feel pressure to eat or drink something specific to "keep supply up." For most people, that pressure isn't backed by strong evidence — a generally adequate, varied diet does the job just as well as any specialised product.

Worth knowing: Foods and drinks marketed to boost milk supply — lactation cookies, specific teas, particular grains — don't have strong evidence behind them for most people, and skipping them doesn't put your supply at risk. Adequate overall intake and effective, regular removal of milk (through feeding or pumping) matter far more than any single food.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Idli (4 pieces) with sambar and coconut chutney and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion paratha (2 eggs, 2 paratha) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Mooga sukka (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong beans) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi
- B. Ghee roast chicken (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted chana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal-and-vegetable khichdi with carrots and peas (1 1/2 cups, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Kori gassi (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — A snack within reach during the session itself

Pumping sessions often leave your hands occupied, which makes eating mid-session impractical. Prepping something you can eat just before or right after — nuts, a boiled egg, fruit already cut — is more realistic than trying to snack while pumping itself. Keep a boiled egg or cut fruit refrigerated, or in an insulated bag with a frozen cold pack, and discard it if it's been left without temperature control for more than two hours, or one hour above 32°C.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Neer dosa with jaggery (3 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Alsande sukka with pundi (3 pieces pundi, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked cowpeas) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Mangalorean fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup) and a cauliflower sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-peas curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — Coordinating pumping breaks with actual meals

When pumping breaks and meal breaks compete for the same short window, meals can end up skipped entirely. Where your schedule allows it, pairing a pumping session with a meal or snack — rather than treating them as two separate demands on the same block of time — can make both easier to fit in.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Neer dosa with cardamom (3 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable omelette (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Mooga sukka (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong beans) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi
- B. Prawn gassi, Mangalorean prawn curry (100g prawns) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted makhana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Egg curry, Mangalorean-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — Supply fluctuates for many reasons, not just food

A lower-output pumping session doesn't necessarily mean you ate the wrong thing that day — stress, how recently you last fed or pumped, time of day, and plenty of other factors all play a role. It's worth resisting the urge to trace a single session back to a single meal.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Semolina upma with mixed vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Alsande sukka with mooga sukka (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked cowpeas) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans-and-carrot sabzi
- B. Kori gassi (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans-and-carrot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Chana dal-and-vegetable khichdi with cauliflower and beans (1 1/2 cups, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Mangalorean mutton curry (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Neer dosa (3 pieces) with coconut chutney and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Alsande sukka, cowpea stir-fry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked cowpeas) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Kori gassi, Mangalorean chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a carrot sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

What's one small change to your pumping-and-eating routine this week that made the day feel a little less rushed?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

The next set of weeks continues this series' steady, one-topic-at-a-time approach to your own nutrition and wellbeing.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.
- There's no strong evidence that any specific food or drink reliably increases milk supply — treat "supply food" marketing claims with the same scepticism as any other unverified health claim.
- Keep curd, cooked eggs and other perishable foods refrigerated, or in an insulated bag with frozen cold packs, and refrigerate on arrival where possible. An insulated bag alone, without a cold pack, isn't enough. Discard perishables left without temperature control for more than two hours — or one hour above 32°C — since refrigerating them again afterward does not make them safe.

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 138

REWORK v2 — correction for review, original remains locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Biotin (vitamin B7), and the one lab-test detail worth remembering

"Biotin supports everyday energy metabolism and is found in cooked egg yolk, nuts, seeds, sweet potato and mushrooms — deficiency is rare, hair/skin/nail supplement claims aren't well supported for people who aren't deficient, and the one genuine caution is telling your clinician or lab if you take a biotin supplement before any blood test, since it can skew certain results."

Why it matters now

Biotin (vitamin B7) is a B vitamin your body uses as part of everyday energy metabolism. Cooked egg yolk, nuts, seeds, sweet potato, mushrooms and whole grains are all reliable sources, and a genuine dietary deficiency is uncommon. One specific detail worth knowing: raw or very undercooked egg white, eaten regularly in large amounts, contains a protein that binds biotin and can reduce absorption — cooking eggs fully, already this series' standard food-safety guidance, avoids this.

Biotin is widely marketed in hair, skin and nail supplements, though the evidence for a meaningful benefit in people who aren't deficient is limited. The one genuinely important safety point is about supplements, not food: biotin supplements can interfere with certain lab tests, including thyroid function and cardiac troponin tests, producing misleading results. Tell the healthcare team about any biotin-containing supplement, including the dose and when you last took it, before a blood test — but don't delay urgent care to do so, and follow their instructions about whether to pause it.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

If you take a biotin supplement and have a blood test coming up: tell your clinician and the lab, including the dose and when you last took it — biotin can interfere with certain results, including thyroid and cardiac troponin tests. Follow their instructions about whether to pause it, and don't delay urgent care to do this.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Purvanchal/Bhojpuri home cooking (poori-chokha, bharwa baingan, dal-poori, and similar), using moong, masoor, toor and chana dal rather than khesari (grass pea) dal — khesari's β -ODAP content is best avoided in a standard weekly menu. If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

Biotin (vitamin B7) is another B vitamin your body uses as part of everyday energy metabolism. It's found in cooked egg yolk, nuts, seeds, sweet potato, mushrooms and whole grains, among other foods, and a genuine deficiency is uncommon with a varied diet.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Poori (2 pieces) with aloo-baingan chokha and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Masoor dal (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked masoor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bharwa baingan
- B. Poorbi mutton curry (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bharwa baingan

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Cooked egg yolk is a good source — cooked egg white matters too

Egg yolk, once cooked, is a reliable everyday biotin source. This is one of the few places in this series where a specific cooking detail connects directly to a nutrient — another good reason, alongside food safety, to cook eggs fully rather than eating them raw or very undercooked.

Worth knowing: Eating a large amount of raw or undercooked egg white regularly can bind biotin and reduce how much your body absorbs, because raw egg white contains a protein (avidin) that binds it. Cooking eggs fully — already this series' standard food-safety guidance, avoiding runny yolks — inactivates avidin and avoids this altogether.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Poori with aloo-tamatar chokha (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Bharwa baingan with toor dal (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked)
- B. Poorbi chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bharwa baingan

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a bhindi sabzi
- B. Egg curry, poorbi-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — Hair, skin and nail supplement claims, kept in perspective

Biotin is widely marketed in hair, skin and nail supplements. For people who already get enough biotin from food and aren't deficient, the evidence that extra biotin meaningfully improves hair or nail growth is limited — a varied diet already covers most people's needs without an additional supplement.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Chuda-dahi, flattened rice with curd and jaggery (1 cup rice, 150g curd)
- B. Egg-and-onion paratha (2 eggs, 2 paratha) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Moong dal with bharwa baingan (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal) with rice (1 cup cooked)
- B. Poorbi mutton curry (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a lauki sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted chana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Dal-poori (2 pieces, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal filling) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Paneer-and-peas curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — If you take a biotin supplement and need a blood test

This is the one genuinely important safety point about biotin, and it's about supplements, not food — mention any biotin supplement before routine or urgent blood work, especially thyroid tests or, in an emergency setting, cardiac tests. Urgent care always comes first; the supplement detail can be mentioned as soon as it's practical to do so.

Worth knowing: Biotin supplements, including many hair/skin/nail products and some multivitamins, can interfere with certain lab tests — including thyroid function tests and cardiac troponin tests — producing falsely abnormal or falsely normal results. Tell your clinician and the lab about any biotin-containing supplement, including the dose and when you last took it, and follow their instructions about whether to pause it. Don't delay urgent care to do this.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Poori with mixed vegetable chokha (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-spinach bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Bharwa baingan with rice (1 cup rice) and a chana dal (includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal)
- B. Poorbi chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a lauki sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Egg curry, poorbi-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a mushroom sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — Good options if you eat mostly vegetarian

Nuts, seeds, sweet potato, mushrooms, whole grains and legumes all contribute biotin without needing meat, fish or eggs — a plant-forward day covers this comfortably as long as it includes some variety across these groups.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Poori with aloo chokha (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-vegetable sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Toor dal (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a mushroom sabzi

B. Poorbi-style rohu fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bharwa baingan

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with an urad dal (3/4 cup)

B. Paneer-and-capsicum curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — The pattern across your week matters, not one meal

One meal without an obvious biotin source doesn't change anything meaningfully — as with the other B vitamins this series has covered, it's the overall pattern of varied meals across the week, not any single plate, that matters.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Vegetable dalia, cracked wheat porridge with mixed vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-tomato bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Masoor dal with rice (1 cup rice, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked masoor dal) and a bharwa baingan

B. Poorbi mutton curry (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans-and-carrot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

A. Moong dal-and-vegetable khichdi with mushrooms and peas (1 1/2 cups, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Poorbi chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Poori (2 pieces) with aloo-baingan chokha and a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Masoor dal (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked masoor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bharwa baingan

B. Poorbi mutton curry (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bharwa baingan

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup)

B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Looking back across this run of weeks, which single change has made the most noticeable difference to how you feel day to day?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

The next set of weeks continues this series' steady, one-topic-at-a-time approach to your own nutrition and wellbeing.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.
- If you take a biotin-containing supplement, tell your clinician and the lab, including the dose and when you last took it, before any blood test — it can interfere with certain results, including thyroid function and cardiac troponin tests. Don't delay urgent care to do this; follow their instructions about whether to pause it.